

A GUIDE TO HEALING IBS, SIBO, AND LEAKY GUT

Leaky Gut

Understanding intestinal hyperpermeability & the
root causes behind IBS, SIBO, and chronic
autoimmune symptoms

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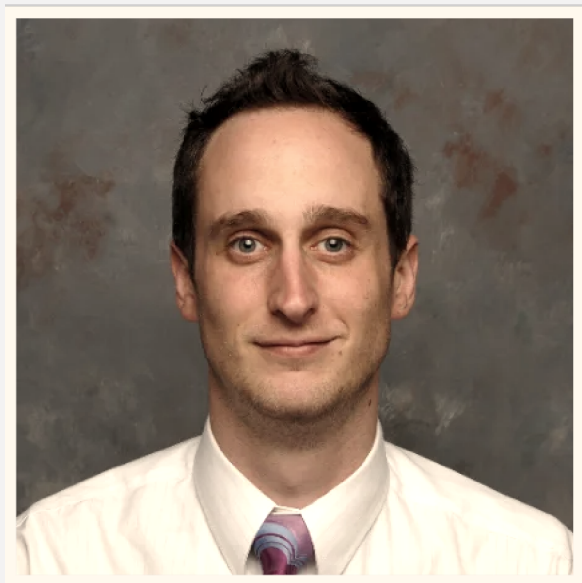
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Hello!



Hey everyone! I just wanted to thank you for taking the time to read this eBook. My sincerest hope is that it will be helpful to you. I consider it a pleasure to serve others and help them get on the road to healing.

Over the years I have worked with many people seeking help with difficult health issues. If you've read any of my articles, you'll see that leaky gut is one of the main topics — the gut is at the root of

many of the chronic issues we deal with today. I wrote this eBook in hopes that you may find specific answers to the things troubling you. Wherever you are on your road to healing, I hope it serves you well.

Once again, thanks for reading. If you have any questions, please don't hesitate to reach out — I'm easy to get ahold of by email or phone, and more than happy to help you handle your difficult gut issues.

Best regards,

Dr. Gabe Ariciu, DC

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An Effective Approach

If you have researched leaky gut, IBS, SIBO, IBD, or any other gut issue, you know it can be quite difficult to treat. Some of these are often managed rather than treated. Sometimes the etiology — where it came from — is "unknown." I wrote this eBook to make it easier to find out what is going on and get at the root of the gut issues.

As helpful as this will be, please understand it is not the same as an in-office visit. I have many tools at my disposal in my office that make treatment far more effective. That said, there is much you can learn and do on your own.

This eBook will help you get on the right track. I also hope it will help you avoid some of the issues my patients have run into in the past — issues that waste time and money. So I've included some of the important and effective approaches from my clinical experience.

As much as I love to read and learn, this will not cover every way the "top" functional medicine doctors treat. Rather, this comes from my clinical experience, from the trenches — what has worked time and time again for my patients. My most effective and efficient ways of looking at various gut issues.

The Why

My expertise focuses on figuring out the *why*. Why is this happening, what is the root cause, and how do we prevent it from happening again? In that way, it may be very different from your favorite influencers.

You'll get a peek behind the curtain, so to speak. I want to show you what often isn't talked about or is overlooked.

What You Will Learn

- How research can differ from what really works
- Top reasons why nothing has worked in the past with other treatments, and what to do about it
- What needs to be addressed first, before addressing leaky gut

Throughout this book I'll be using the term **leaky gut**. It's much more common than its scientific name, *intestinal hyperpermeability*. Leaky gut leads to multiple chronic issues, including autoimmune conditions such as Crohn's, but also SIBO, IBS, thyroid issues, hormone imbalances, and even mental health problems. Numerous issues can stem from it — so addressing leaky gut and what causes it is at the root of the others, and it's much less complicated than it sounds.

What is Leaky Gut?

I always start this off with an analogy. I like to compare the gut to a castle. Castles first and foremost have strong exterior walls with gates that can be opened and closed. Some also have a moat around them. The gut is similar — it is lined with cells, the wall; there is a mucus layer, the moat; and we have soldiers, the immune cells.

Of course, we want certain things in — your gut is designed to digest food and absorb its nutrients. But just like in a castle, breaches in the wall can happen, and what it was keeping out is now being allowed in. These can be pathogens, toxins, and undigested foods. This is hyperpermeability, otherwise known as leaky gut.

About 80% of your immune system lies in your gut. Its job is to keep track of what is going on and not allow foreign invaders in. When the gut leaks, the immune system becomes alerted — a good thing, since we need it to stop any damaging thing from entering. However, if this is never resolved, it can lead to many other things.

First, it takes a toll on the immune system, which becomes taxed with the ongoing effort to keep this under control. This then leads to localized inflammation that, if unchecked, can become systemic inflammation, resulting in issues such as autoimmunity.

So you can see why this is important to address!

What Can Be Done?

The list of things that contribute to leaky gut is long and extensive. It's quite difficult to pinpoint the original culprit. That's one reason I'll often say it's multifaceted and requires a multifaceted approach. The same goes for SIBO and IBS.

The great news is that your gut can heal itself pretty quickly — it replaces itself essentially every 3 to 5 days. So why do so many programs stretch this over several months, even six months or longer? *It shouldn't take that long.*

That is the purpose of this book — to explain what can be done and get you on the road to recovery as quickly as possible. I've included some of my personal tips, tricks, and secrets that help my patients.

Leaky Gut Symptoms

These are varied. Some may not have any symptoms associated with the gut at all, so keep that in mind.

Indigestion

Bloating

Diarrhea

Constipation

Food intolerances

Eczema

Pain

Sick often

Malabsorption

Liver issues

Fatigue

Anxiety

Depression

Abdominal pain

Headaches

Often, those suffering from SIBO and IBS more than likely also have leaky gut. You'll see a lot of overlap — and the treatment will be relatively the same.

IBS and SIBO

Just like with leaky gut, I see IBS and SIBO frequently — even on a daily basis. Many are struggling with this. A good portion of my patients come to me after they have exhausted many other avenues, including other functional medicine practitioners. Why include these with leaky gut? Not only is the treatment similar, but often patients have one or both together with leaky gut.

IBS is kind of a catch-all diagnosis. Not that it doesn't exist — it's just typically diagnosed after other things are ruled out. It often presents with diarrhea or constipation, sometimes a mix (IBS-D or IBS-C). But really it comes down to the fact the gut is irritated, as its name says. The symptoms overlap with SIBO and leaky gut too.

SIBO refers to the overgrowth of bacteria into the small intestine. Most of our bacteria reside in the large intestine, but due to a variety of reasons they overgrow into the small intestine, causing symptoms that again overlap with the others here — bloating, cramping, diarrhea, etc. Diagnosis is typically done via a breath test; treatment remains about the same.

SIFO is another common issue, similar in nature, only it is fungus that overgrows. This can be a bit more difficult to treat, and there is no reliable lab test for it — another great reason to use manual muscle testing. I can't tell you how often I find this in patients.

Now that we've defined these, what are the risk factors for leaky gut?

Risks of Leaky Gut

Earlier I detailed some of the symptoms, but leaky gut can lead to far worse things. Some of the worst chronic conditions today are linked to leaky gut syndrome. These include:

Hashimoto's Thyroiditis

Fibromyalgia

Chronic Fatigue

Migraines

Celiac Disease

Multiple Sclerosis

Lupus

Psoriasis

Rheumatoid Arthritis

Alopecia Areata

...and many more.

Many of these are autoimmune conditions, where the immune system attacks your own tissue. It's important to remember that those with one autoimmune condition are likely to get another. I often liken it to a pack of wolves, each representing a different autoimmune condition — unless we get at the root of the problem, the likelihood of another wolf latching on is high.

What Causes Leaky Gut? – Part 1

There are a number of factors that can cause or contribute to leaky gut – and to IBS and SIBO. This won't be an exhaustive list, but I'll point to the big ones.

Alcohol

Alcohol has many downsides. It is the most abused drug in the world – a toxin that can affect many parts of the body, making it difficult to heal. The gut is no exception. Books can be, and have been, written on the damage alcohol can do.

Caffeine

Caffeine is a gut irritant, and we love it! It doesn't matter how clean the product is, it can still cause issues. Caffeine is a natural pesticide plants use to ward off bugs – so even though there's a nice benefit to it, it can also cause issues to the gut.

Microbes

Gut microbes can cause a variety of issues, including leaky gut. These include fungi, bacteria, parasites, and viruses. They can cause inflammation, severe illness, and release toxins into the body. This is by far the number one issue.

In particular, Candida overgrowth is one of the most common, due to overuse of antibiotics or the standard American diet. It can be difficult to balance.

What Causes Leaky Gut? – Part 2

Additive Toxins

Whether pesticides or chemical additives, this list is long. We live in a heavily processed food world — there are many additives like MSG and food dyes, along with loads of pesticides added to our foods. Each of these contributes to leaky gut by activating our immune system.

GMO foods are another issue — they're modified to withstand heavy pesticide use. Glyphosate is one of the most common herbicides, classified as an antimicrobial. It doesn't necessarily harm us directly — though that's debatable — but it destroys the gut microbiome.

Refined Carbs and Sugars

This is one of the biggest contributors to chronic illness. We eat an excess amount of carbs, which damages our ability to heal, makes us insulin resistant, and feeds all the wrong microbes — contributing to an imbalance in our microbiome.

NSAIDs

We overuse these often. They're well known to damage the stomach and cause ulcers, but they can also cause leaky gut. They impair the immune system as well — so not only are they damaging your gut, they're impairing your ability to heal too.

What Causes Leaky Gut? – Part 3

Acid-Reducers

Antacids are among the most commonly used over-the-counter medications. They decrease the amount of acid in the stomach, which contributes to long-term issues. Most of the time our issue is that we don't have enough acid — often due to stress or the presence of microbes decreasing our stomach acid, sometimes nutrient issues. Either way, antacids worsen the problem over time and lead to gut issues.

Antibiotics

These are a life-saver when used correctly, but we've been overusing them for a long time. As much as they can help, they have some pretty negative side effects on your gut microbiome — they're designed to kill any bacteria in their path, which leaves you wide open for fungal overgrowth or other infections.

Food Toxins

There are many foods that can contribute to leaky gut, such as when we eat foods that haven't been properly prepared, like wheat. Wheat contains many toxins; traditionally we would sprout and ferment it. When this hasn't happened, the toxins can cause inflammation and damage the gut. For more on this, check out my article, ["What Should Humans Eat?"](#)

Leaky Gut, Leaky Brain

The gut lining isn't alone — the blood-brain barrier is quite similar. It's been shown that almost always, when someone has leaky gut, they also have leaky brain. There is a strong connection between the gut and the brain called the gut-brain axis. In fact, the gut is known as the second brain.

The brain is rather important to me, as I assume it is to you too. It's incredibly frustrating to not be able to think clearly and remember things. People with leaky brain have many symptoms, including:

Brain fog

Loss of focus

Loss of concentration

Depression

Anxiety

Memory loss

Cognitive issues

The same toxins affecting the gut will also affect the brain — giving us another reason to figure out what's going on with the gut, so we can help the brain heal too.

Diagnosis and Conventional Treatment

Most functional medicine practitioners diagnose leaky gut via lactulose and mannitol testing. There are some other, indirect markers that can be screened for in the blood too, though sometimes you can miss it — the same goes for testing SIBO.

Another way is through manual muscle testing by a professional Applied Kinesiologist. It's a great way to screen for issues, and it's what I prefer — I use this along with a thorough health history. It allows me to give immediate feedback and put together an effective treatment plan on the first visit.

What About Conventional Treatment?

Even though leaky gut is becoming more widely known, most conventional doctors don't accept it. It's not hard to find an article saying it doesn't exist or doesn't matter, despite the mountains of research describing it. It's mostly ignored.

IBS tends to be managed by decreasing stress, though there are some medications. For SIBO, it's usually antibiotics, which as I've already touched on can cause other issues. In the end, many are left still struggling and wondering why.

Natural and Functional Medicine Treatment

There are different perspectives in this arena. From my years of experience, it's a bit of a spectrum. Some rely heavily on blood tests and "evidence-based" treatment. Some natural doctors focus mostly on diet and herbs. I've seen many recommend prescriptions alongside diet and lifestyle modifications. But I'd say there are some similarities between them all.

The overall goal of natural and functional approaches is to uncover the **root cause**. Whether they're using lab tests, muscle testing, or a neurofeedback device, they're all seeking the root cause of what's going on — which is great, this is what we want, and it's my approach too.

Most tend to be well versed in anti-inflammatory or elimination diets. Supplementation varies between practitioners, though there are some common approaches. Many of these are well and good, but oftentimes the underlying culprit is overlooked.

Just because the lab test improves, or evidence supports the approach, it all falls apart when the patient's symptoms are not improving. In other words, we missed something — and sometimes it's something big!

Why is it Not Working?

This is probably the most important part of this eBook. I've gone through hundreds of hours of functional medicine training and thousands of hours of clinical experience. Many things contribute to a treatment not working — and just because a treatment is popular or touted by all the popular gurus doesn't mean it's effective or what you need.

Part of the issue is that many of the gurus you may be listening to are researchers, not clinicians. Research is important, but what happens in a laboratory is often different from a clinical setting — many hours spent researching, very few implementing. I've seen it firsthand: I've listened to gurus talk about the research, then used what they recommend and not gotten the intended results.

So I'll detail what I've seen as stumbling blocks in treatment protocols, and why. I hope it's not too controversial — I don't mean to step on anyone's toes. Rather, I hope this will help you avoid some of the pitfalls I've seen and find the resolution you're seeking.

Silent Infections

This is super important — I don't know how many times I've seen this ignored or overlooked. I've also seen others openly admit to not knowing what to do about it. Still others do their best, but ultimately wind up with a generic protocol meant to fit everyone. Nothing against them, it can be complicated, at least at first.

WHY IS IT NOT WORKING? — CONTINUED

Why is this so important? It's probably the number one reason behind leaky gut, and it must be addressed. It's also the number one reason people find themselves on ever more restrictive diets — as soon as they reincorporate foods, the symptoms return, or they take probiotics that only mask the symptoms and return the moment they stop.

Silent infections are really common too — pretty much everyone walking into my office is dealing with one. The same could be said of leaky gut; almost every patient leaves with one or two natural antimicrobials. If these aren't addressed, the root cause isn't addressed — so the leaky gut, the symptoms, the restrictive diets, and the masking all continue.

The Wrong Antimicrobial

Another common issue is the wrong herb. Quality matters here and is not something to compromise on — the same herb can come from very different sources, and it needs to be a clean, high-quality one.

Further, just because something is an antimicrobial doesn't mean it's the one you need. I always use manual muscle testing to fine-tune what herbs are needed. It's common to see patients who have tried herbs like garlic, oregano oil, elderberry, and others to no avail — some are just not strong enough, so it's important to be properly tested on herbs strong enough to help.

Of those I mentioned, I keep elderberry in my office but use it for specific things, usually to support the immune system. Oregano oil is in some of my essential oil products, used in conjunction with others for specific cases. I more often use other herbs better suited to the issue at hand.

WHY IS IT NOT WORKING? — CONTINUED

Turmeric and Resveratrol

This is often a joke among my colleagues and me. Not that these don't work — they do! But you can't go ten seconds without hearing about these two supplements, or the word “inflammation,” which they're intended to treat.

Don't get me wrong, we need to deal with inflammation — however, your body is not inflamed for no reason. **Inflammation is not the root cause.** Something else is driving it; we must find the driver. That said, I commonly use curcumin (from turmeric) and resveratrol in my office when appropriate, but it's not part of a cookie-cutter protocol — rather, I test for it per individual to know if it's needed.

Anti-Inflammatory Diet

This is not a supplement, obviously, however it's strongly employed. If someone is still having symptoms — meaning they start eating those foods again and symptoms return — we've missed something. Nevertheless, it's an important and crucial tool. And a side note: some foods will cause symptoms, period. These include food intolerances and foods that aren't optimal for humans, like nuts and legumes. The severity depends on the person — but if you're only eating meat because everything causes symptoms, something else is going on.

Glutamine

I don't typically use this in my office; however, I'm perfectly comfortable recommending it, as it can help the gut heal. That said, glutamine is like the others — if the root cause isn't discovered and dealt with, taking glutamine is like pouring water into a leaky barrel.

WHY IS IT NOT WORKING? — CONTINUED

Probiotics

I already touched on these. Super common these days — many think they healed their issues, but in reality they masked them. The underlying issue must be dealt with first and foremost. Afterwards, probiotics can help replenish the gut, but typically I recommend fermented foods, organic fruits and vegetables, and others.

Food Intolerances

I mentioned these earlier. If you have leaky gut, it's quite possible you've become intolerant or sensitive to certain foods, like gluten or eggs. It's important to remove these, and crucial to treatment. This is often looked at, which is good, but it's looked at alone, at the neglect of silent infections.

Fiber and Prebiotics

This will be controversial. Fiber is not what it's cracked up to be. Humans do not have a large gut built to handle the amount that's recommended, and our gut microbiome does not need that much. In fact, many have an increase in symptoms, including bloating and constipation, when they consume large amounts of fiber.

Omega-3s and Vitamin D

These are fantastic — I use them frequently. However, again, if the underlying cause isn't found and dealt with, it's again pouring water into a leaky barrel. That goes for many vitamins and minerals too.

Moral of the story? The root cause must be addressed. And what is the main root cause I'm detailing? **Silent infections.**

Natural Antimicrobials

How do you address silent infections? With natural antimicrobials. I've included five of my most common ones in hopes they may be helpful to you on your journey to health and healing. This is not an exhaustive list. Herbs are typically safe — I usually don't keep patients on them long, roughly two weeks, sometimes longer. As always, consult with your physician; they can advise you on how long to take them and which are needed.

Neem (*Melia azadirachta*)

[Buy here](#)

Neem has been used for thousands of years. It's a broad-spectrum antimicrobial that can even help against drug-resistant bacteria, and has been shown to spare the good bacteria. It has some anti-inflammatory and anti-histamine properties, and has been shown to help with serotonin, insulin, and cholesterol too.

Noni (*Morinda citrifolia*)

[Buy here](#)

If you've ever visited the Pacific islands you may have heard of noni, frequently used as juice. Noni can help with a variety of issues, including supporting the immune system, cognition, and blood sugar. I mainly use it for its broad-spectrum antimicrobial properties — shown to help against bacteria and fungi especially, but others too.

NATURAL ANTIMICROBIALS, CONTINUED

Chinese Coptis (*Coptis chinensis*)[Buy here](#)

Chinese coptis is a broad-spectrum antimicrobial that can help with a variety of infections, and has been shown to help with biofilms — the fortress-like structures microbes create. It also contains berberine: anti-inflammatory, calming to the sympathetic nervous system, and supportive of bile production for gallbladder issues.

Mimosa (*Mimosa pudica*)[Buy here](#)

Don't confuse it with the drink of the same name. Mimosa has been used for a very long time in Asia — a broad-spectrum antimicrobial, but specifically against parasites, and one of the most common I use for such issues. It's also been shown to support the liver and blood sugar regulation.

Chinese Skullcap (*Scutellaria baicalensis*)[Buy here](#)

Chinese skullcap is a broad-spectrum antimicrobial and among the safest I use — it can be used during pregnancy and breastfeeding, and has been shown to help against drug-resistant microbes. It's cardioprotective, neuroprotective, hepatoprotective, anti-inflammatory, and kidney-protective.

A Note on Herbs and Supplements

I already mentioned quality. Some other things to look for are extra ingredients — for herbs, make sure nothing extra is added, such as fillers or binders. Other supplements will have some of these added, though still good quality.

Along with sourcing well, herbs should also be organic — and they shouldn't be grown next to an active volcano or a coal plant.

Lastly, single ingredients are best. Combination supplements rarely work well in my experience. I'm often asked about B-complexes or herb combos, and I always point out that most of my supplements are single ingredients, such as niacinamide (Vitamin B3).

Where to Buy Them?

Of course, I carry them in my office. Many of my supplements can be purchased through my [Fullscript account](#). The herbs can be found at the links in the previous pages.

Appendix: Diet

For most patients, I recommend a modified Paleo diet — essentially meat, fruit, and vegetables. This is the closest we can get to mimicking the diet of our ancestors. It doesn't mean you'll be 100% Paleo the rest of your life, but during healing it's highly recommended. Thereafter, many find eating Paleo 80–90% of the time works well.

That said, some patients need a stricter diet. Those with fungal infections especially need to be careful about certain foods. I often start with an antifungal diet, avoiding sweeteners and mold-fermented foods. Then, if needed — and it often is — I'll move toward FODMAPs, which excludes other carbohydrates likely to cause issues with fungal infections. It's not the only time I use it, but it's common, and while difficult, it can be a game-changer on the road to healing.

For more information on Paleo, I recommend trying Whole30 — essentially the same thing. You can find the program rules here: [Whole30 Program Rules](#).

Appendix: The Right Approach

Finding the right supplement can be hard, as I mentioned.

Trial and Error

In my experience, finding the right herb on your own can take time. I included five of my most common herbs used in my office — most patients do very well on them. However, with gut issues, I often see two herbs being needed. You may need to combine two of them and try them for two weeks.

Find the Right Doctor

Whatever route you choose, I highly recommend finding a skilled Professional Applied Kinesiologist familiar with silent infections — it will save you so much time and effort, especially if they use Systems Health Care technique. It's much easier than trying a million supplements to no avail.

If you need a referral, don't hesitate to reach out at doc@drariciu.com. I don't know if there will be someone in your area, but I'll do my best to help you find someone. If not, I do offer virtual appointments — though not the same as an in-office visit, they can still be very helpful.

[Book an Appointment](#)

Appendix: Disclaimer

As always, and as already mentioned, this is meant for educational purposes only and is not intended to constitute (i) medical advice or counseling, (ii) the practice of medicine including psychiatry, psychology, psychotherapy, or the provision of health care diagnosis or treatment, (iii) the creation of a physician-patient or clinical relationship, or (iv) an endorsement, recommendation, or sponsorship of any third-party product or service by the Sponsor or any of the Sponsor's affiliates, agents, employees, consultants, or service providers.

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As safe as herbs and supplements are, they can still cause issues. The safest way to determine this is by seeing your physician.

Frequently Asked Questions

What about _____?

I wish I could be more specific, but it's impossible to anticipate everyone's needs. Please don't hesitate to reach out — I also do virtual appointments, whatever works best for you. I'm happy to help answer your specific questions if I can. Of course, you can also schedule an in-office appointment too.

What about antibiotics?

As I said earlier, they can cause a lot of damage. I'm not against them — they're a life-saving development — but they're indiscriminate about the bacteria they kill, and they're designed to only kill bacteria, which creates opportunities for other microbes to grow. Antimicrobial herbs, by contrast, are broad spectrum — they can often kill not only bacteria but also fungi, parasites, and viruses, and tend to balance rather than decimate your gut flora.

What if I've tried antimicrobial herbs before?

This goes back to what I said earlier — quality and sourcing matter, as does the herb you specifically need. I use only the best; if a supplement doesn't test well in my office, I don't use it. My patients often bring in herbs from other companies that just don't test well. It could also be that you have other issues that need to be addressed — the liver may need support, or another organ. For example, aldehyde toxicity is common with fungal infections.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS, CONTINUED

What else can I do to support healing?

Diet is super important — I go into great detail about diet in my office. In addition, exercise and movement are super helpful; I have several optimizing strategies I recommend to patients. But first is diet and movement — start by walking, then progress to something more intense. Many need a program or a trainer; there are good at-home options too. The point is to get moving. Then start slowly cleaning up your environment: get a good water filter, change out hygiene products for cleaner ones.

How can I find a physician?

Definitely hard, but they can be found. Once you find one, hold on to them — they're priceless. Feel free to reach out to me at doc@drariciu.com and maybe I can help you find someone in your area. Happy to help!

What about lab testing?

I love lab work — it's fascinating to read and understand. That said, it can be very expensive and inconclusive. Don't get me wrong, I run labs when needed, especially to manage things like thyroid. However, so often they're incredibly costly and you still don't have great answers. That's why I use manual muscle testing and recommend finding a skilled, certified professional Applied Kinesiologist — it can save you a lot of money and headaches.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS, CONTINUED

Why muscle testing?

It's the most effective and efficient means of finding the root cause. With Applied Kinesiology, specifically [Systems Health Care](#), the treatment can be fine-tuned and individualized. I'm able to figure things out quite quickly with it. So again, I highly recommend finding a skilled professional Applied Kinesiologist.

What about stool testing?

I've been asked this many times. It's not something I tend to do — many microbes are missed, and it can be inconclusive. If it finds what's going on, great. But often thousands are spent on testing and the treatment is inadequate. I don't know how many patients I've seen who have spent thousands, sometimes over ten thousand, just to get a diagnosis, only to have the treatment be ineffective.

Do you have a protocol?

I do not. I've had patients test for and exhibit the exact same issues who needed different herbs. Cookie-cutter protocols often don't work, or are subpar.

Conclusion

Thanks for taking the time to read this eBook. I hope it helps. There is so much more detail to go into — I have several blog posts going into greater depth on leaky gut. For those who want to take a deeper dive, please check out: [Intestinal Permeability: Leaky Gut's Role in Autoimmune Disease](#).

Leaky gut is an important aspect to address when trying to heal, but it's not the only one — a holistic approach is what's needed. If you're still struggling, please don't hesitate to reach out.

In the end, I hope this at the very least gives you hope. There is always hope. Don't give up — there is a light at the end of the tunnel.

If you found this helpful, please share it with a friend.

LEAKY GUT

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